Lives of the Great Waitresses

By Nina Shengold

YETTA, KAY, TAMMIE SUE, *prepping the breakfast shift. All in pink uniforms.*

INTRODUCTION

Being a great waitress is a real accomplishment. There is a huge difference between a good and a "GREAT" waitress. I have seen and worked with many good waitresses over the years, but I've only run into a few great ones. There are many little techniques that veteran waitresses learn that improve their efficiency, get them larger gratuities, and elevate them to the top of the heap. However, there seems to be a large mental shift that a waitress must make before she can truly be a great waitress. Well, actually, I know of some people who can show you what I mean much better than I can tell you. Let me introduce you to Kay, Tammie Sue, Yetta and Melissa from Lives of the Great Waitresses by Nina Shengold

KAY: You either got it, or you don't. If you don't, you won't ever. So don't even bother. Don't strain. Oh, there's things you can learn, sure. The fine points. The stance. "Heat that up for you?" "Toasted?" But honey-scratch that, make it hon-a truly great waitress is *born.*

You get what I mean? It's a feel thing. Deep under the bones of your bones. In your cells. Some reporter once asked Louis Armstrong what "swing" meant. Louis looked the guy dead in the eyeball and said, "If you gotta ask, you'll never know." *He* would've made a great waitress.

My very first diner, we had one. Flo Kelly. A goddess in Supp-hose. Flo was all waitress. She could fill two dozen shakers one-handed and never spill one grain of salt. She could carry eight Hungry Man specials lined up on her arm like a charm bracelet. Flo could serve pie a la mode so it looked like Mount Everest topping the clouds. She poured gravy like tropical rain. In Flo's maraschino-nailed fingers, the short-order

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carousel spun like the Wheel of Fortune, and never, not once, did a customer's coffee get cold.

Well, I mean to tell you, that diner was *hers.* If Jesus Himself Amen came in and sat down to supper, he would've tipped double. Then one Blue-Plate Special, right after the lunch rush, Flo hung up her hairnet, cashed in her checks, and went sunny-side up. And that's when the Lord took my order. I knew what I was. I was called. *(She steps closer.)*

Look in my eyes. I know mysteries way beyond menus. I have felt the Lord's love pierce my heart like a skewer through gyros. I have seen Jesus weep ice-kold milk with a K. *(She holds out her hand.)*

Heat that up for you? Han?

(BLACKOUT. LIGHTS UP on TAMMIE SUE, filling up sugar shakers. Forties, dithery, slight Southern twang

TAMMIE SUE: SO this fella sits down at my counter. Scrawny, beat, banty thing, ugly as yesterday's homefries, and he's got the look. You all know that look. *(She demonstrates.)*

There's this puppy dog whimpering back of his eyes, means he's looking for more than two eggs on a raft, wreck 'em, cuppa joe light. So I do what a girl's gotta do. I ignore him. No warmups, no sass, save my smile for the grandpas and wedding rings in the next booth. Comes the end of my shift, and this shriveled-up walnut, this cottage cheese curd, this crust of burnt toast is still sitting there. Dog in his eyes rolls right over and begs.

So I give him the deep-freeze. I shoot him a look that would flatten meringue. *(She demonstrates.)*

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And what's he do? Smiles at me. *Smiles.* Gatty teeth, great big space in the middle, looked just like a little ole kid with skinned knees on the playground.

Well, hell. That did melt me up. Kay's always telling me I got a heart as big as a Butterball turkey, and besides it's been way, way too long since my griddle got greased. So we go to the motor home up top his semi.

Well. I tell you that man had a mouth that could melt you like butter and syrup on top of a short stack of buckwheats. He did things with his fingers that should be illegal, or fattening. That little runt had him a secret self under his outfit. We've all of us got one, but this was a secret worth spreading around. And he did. He most certainly did. He could love you up one side and back down the other and still leave the middle part gasping for more. That man had a gift. Mashed potatoes and gravy. I left him a tip, that's the God's honest truth.

So the next time you find yourself checking out someone's dessert case, remember, it isn't the Dream Whip that counts. It's the peach in the pie.

(She pours sugar straight into her hand, sticks her tongue in it. BLACKOUT. LIGHTS BACK UP on YETTA, drying her feet and pulling on flesh colored knee-highs and nurse's shoes.)

YETTA: We got us a new one today. Little blondie thing. Brains like a dishrag. Marty says to me, Yetta, give her a try. What try. Way she walks into the *room* I can tell you the broad ain't no waitress. She's got this two

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hundred and ninety pound bag slung over her shoulder, you just *know* that it's gonna be full of her face eight by ten. You *know* that she's gonna be hocking the customers, "Hi! I'm-"

(MELISSA, twenty, walks on with a musical comedy smile. Brand new uniform.)

MELISSA: *(Overlapping.)-I'm* Melissa. Our specials tonight are a light cappellini with sauce Margherita-

YETTA: Spaghetti and meatballs.

MELISSA: -a baked beef and pork terrine,

YETTA: Meatloaf

MELISSA: -and I want to thank my parents, my agent, and God for believing in me.

YETTA: A question. Does *anyone* care what's the name of the person who's pouring your coffee cup? *Thank* you.

MELISSA: Gemini. Capricorn rising.

YETTA: My *breakfast* is rising.

MELISSA: "The quality of mercy is not strained." *(Bright smile, starts to sing)* "Brigadoon, Brigadoooooonn ... "

YETTA: Am I right or right? Hopeless. First lunch rush, her head'll be spinning around like the milkshake machine. But she bats her big blues up at Marty and tells him yes, she's got experience. Marty, being A) dense and B) male, does not ask her what kind. So it's up to yours truly to break the kid in. Never mind I got migraines in both of my feet. Tammie Sue knows her ass from her elbow on good days, and Kay's gonna try to convert her. Born *once*, she can just about handle, forget born again. So I give her the counter,

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okay? Let her piss off the regulars. Marty's there working the register, maybe he'll know from "experience" next time around. Which I bet you good odds is the end of this shift.

(MELISSA takes pad and pencil out of her apron, approaches an imaginary customer on the fourth wall with a big nervous smile.)

MELISSA: Hi. Can I get you some breakfast? Um, coffee? Uh huh ... *(She writes on her pad, very slowly and clearly.)* Is that "regular" meaning not decaf, or regular with cream and-Right. What? Oh, *menus,* I'm sorry ... Right back. *(She scuttles out. YETTA smirks.)*

YETTA: And we're off. And it doesn't get better. Clear through to the lunch rush she's mixing up eggs over easy supposed to be scrambled. She's bringing the Western the wattles. She's dropping forks right, left, and center. The decaf goes dry. Then she loses an order, a party of six, and they walk without paying. *(MELISSA rushes out, breathless.)*

MELISSA: I'm sorry it's taking so long, I'm- ... Hello? *(She looks towards the exit, near tears.)*

YETTA: SO I look over at Marty like, hey, get the hook, because Miss Eight by Ten flunked her audition. And Marty just flashes his not-quite-so-pearlies-the *breath* on that man, it could kill you-and says, "Listen, everyone'sgotta start somewhere." I'll tell him where *I'd* like to start. With his head on a plate. A klug of him. I need a cigarette. *(She reaches for one. BLACKOUT. LIGHTS UP on MELISSA, untying her apron, alone.)*

MELISSA: This is my first day of work. Not here. Ever. My family had money

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and nobody made me. I came to this city to look for a job and nobody would hire me. It's kind of like being a virgin-I'm not any more, but I was-and I'm telling you, nobody wants to be first. Too much pressure. My roommate said, "Lie." So I did. *(She sits.)* People think if you haven't done something before, you're an idiot. People can't know what's inside you. You don't know yourself till you're given a chance. Then all of a sudden this new personality starts to swell under your skin, bursting through where you'd never expect it, and nothing you thought you were makes any sense. You're elastic. You're putty. You've been up for hours, making love to a man whose back ripples with muscles you've never felt, feeling your body expand and explode and dissolve into air, into something like stars, and it doesn't seem possible that you could open your eyes to the same old alarm clock and fit in the same pair of shoes.

I don't want to lose this. This newness, this urgent, sharp knowledge that everything matters. That being good matters. I want to do everything well.

I know, I'm a waitress. It's not what I've dreamed of, what anyone dreams of, but I make a difference. I do. There are lives on each stool at that counter. The old man who's ordered his Sanka and shredded wheat every morning for twenty-five years. *(She nods toward someone in the audience.)* Otto.

The woman who fought with her husband last night and treated herself to French toast with her friend who just had a mastectomy. Velma and Ruth. The man who panhandled the price

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of his coffee. Muhammed. I touch them. I give them the quiet sensation that once in their sad, uncontrollable lives, they wanted a small thing and got it. I brought it. I bore them a gift. And that matters. *(She hangs up her apron, on a transparent hook hanging down from clear fishing line.)* You watch me. I'm going to be brilliant. I'm going to be one of the greats.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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